debriefing, this topic came up again. We resolved to go deeper into the matter.

As luck would have it, we got some intelligence only a few weeks later of a cache of arms in the same village. The cache was uncovered and several weapons, explosives and devices to remotely detonate explosive devices were recovered from the fields belonging to Razzaq Khan. As the owner of the fields, we had no choice but to arrest him for offences under various laws of the land. Once again, the crowd turned hostile. This time it was an all-women crowd. I hastily called for the mukdam and with his help, we managed to pacify the throng. Slowly, I explained to them that we were doing our job. They could come over the next day and meet Razzaq Khan. I gave them my personal guarantee that no harm would befall him. Not entirely convinced, the women went back to their homes, still a little agitated. We returned to the Company post at Malamu, near Magam.

That evening, Razzaq Khan was debriefed in detail. What did he know of this cache? How had it got there, camouflaged under stalks of maize? Why had his son joined militancy? Killed so many people wantonly? These and a host of other questions crowded my mind. I genuinely wanted to know why so many youngsters had chosen the path of violence and taken recourse to the gun. What was the motivation? Why had he not tried to talk sense into his only son? Or did he too secretly support the so-called cause? Over cups of tea and plates of pakoras, we talked late into the night. 'Mustafa was a very bright child,' said Razzaq. 'We had so many hopes for him. As the baby of the family and the only son, he was showered with affection by his mother and sisters. He was a dutiful son but a little headstrong.'

I had to agree with him. Mustafa had certainly been a brainy chap. He had given us and the police the slip many a time. Sometimes posing as a school-going twelfth grader,

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